Centrifuge

Tokenization Outlook 2026

An operator survey across issuance, distribution, liquidity, and infrastructure, showing what the market believes will actually scale tokenized assets in the next 12–18 months.



Made exclusively for

Real-World Asset Summit

Introduction

Between February and March 2026, we surveyed 150 operators across the tokenized asset ecosystem: asset managers, infrastructure providers, DeFi protocols, centralized exchanges, market makers, data platforms, researchers and many others. One response per organization. People shipping, servicing, researching or building markets for tokenized assets.

We wanted to understand what this industry actually believes, stripped of conference narratives and consensus talking points. Where operators agree, where they disagree, and where the gap between what gets discussed and what gets built is widest.

Three findings stood out.

Distribution matters more than issuance. The supply side has matured. Across the ecosystem, operators treat issuance as a solved problem. What's worth developing is the connective tissue: the integrations, venues, and workflows that move tokenized products into active use. 86% of operators agree that scaling distribution matters more than launching new products.

Composability is the real use case. Tokenized T-bills dominate today's narrative, but operators see them as a stepping stone. The primary use case they're building toward is composable products: structured strategies, collateral frameworks, and lending markets where tokenized assets act as active financial instruments rather than passive yield. That's the edge operators expect to widen over the next few years.

Technology is not itself a blocker. Regulatory clarity and liquidity depth account for 76% of bottleneck concerns. Operators don’t think there’s a technical constraint to growing distribution. The infrastructure works. The question is whether the rules and the demand catch up.

This report reflects what we at Centrifuge hear from the people working alongside us, and it challenged some of our own assumptions.

We hope it does the same for you.

Bhaji Illuminati
CEO & Co-Founder, Centrifuge Labs

Methodology

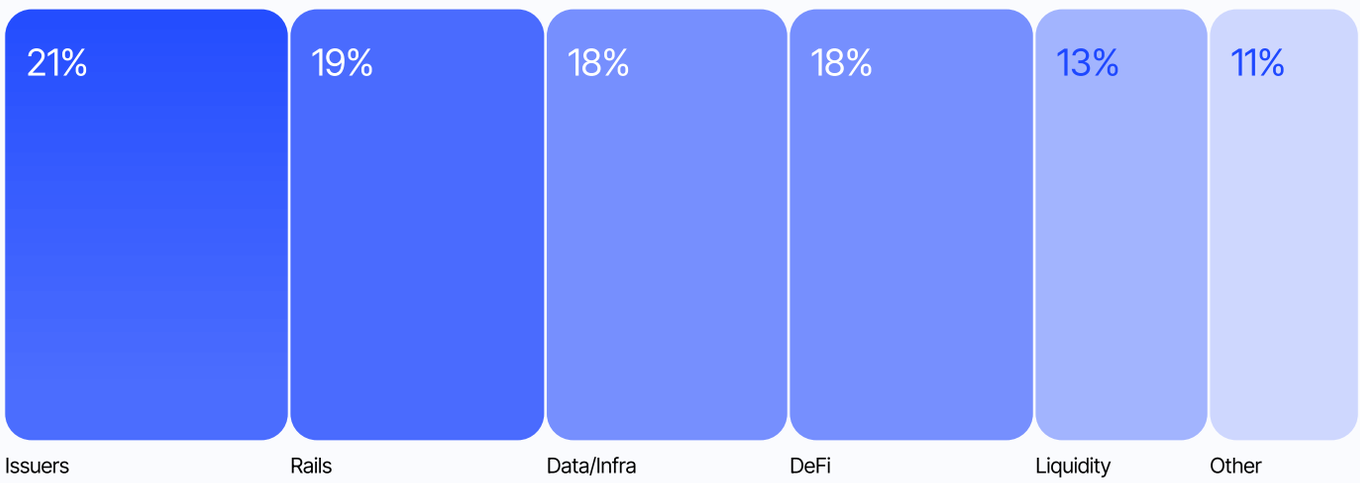
This report is based on a survey of 150 operators directly involved in shipping, operating, or servicing tokenized assets. All respondents have been active in production, piloting, or experimenting with tokenized products within the past 12 months.

Respondents span the full lifecycle of tokenized assets: issuance and structuring, distribution and trading, infrastructure, data, risk analytics, and liquidity provision. Organizations range from crypto-native startups to publicly listed financial institutions, headquartered across North America (38%), Europe (37%), Asia-Pacific (13%), and the Middle East (7%).

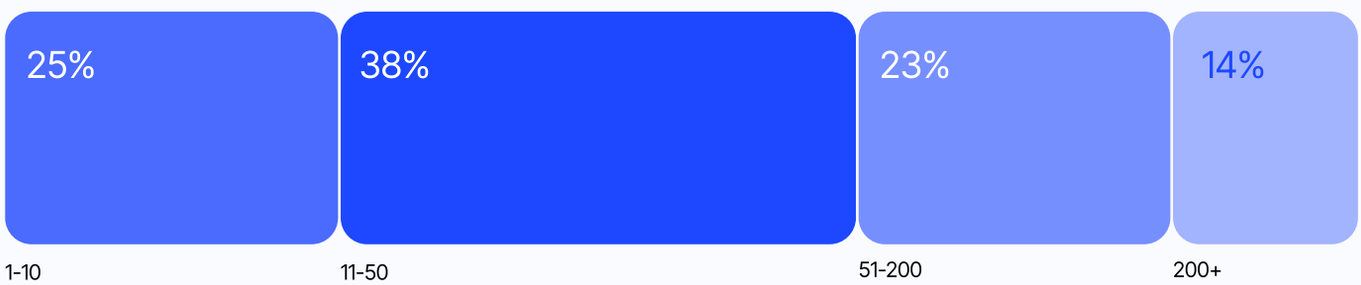
The survey was conducted between February and March 2026. It combines single-select opinion questions, multi-select responses, and scaled confidence ratings. All percentage figures reflect the share of total respondents unless otherwise noted.

Survey respondent profile

Respondents by category



Respondents by headcount



01. The role of tokenized assets

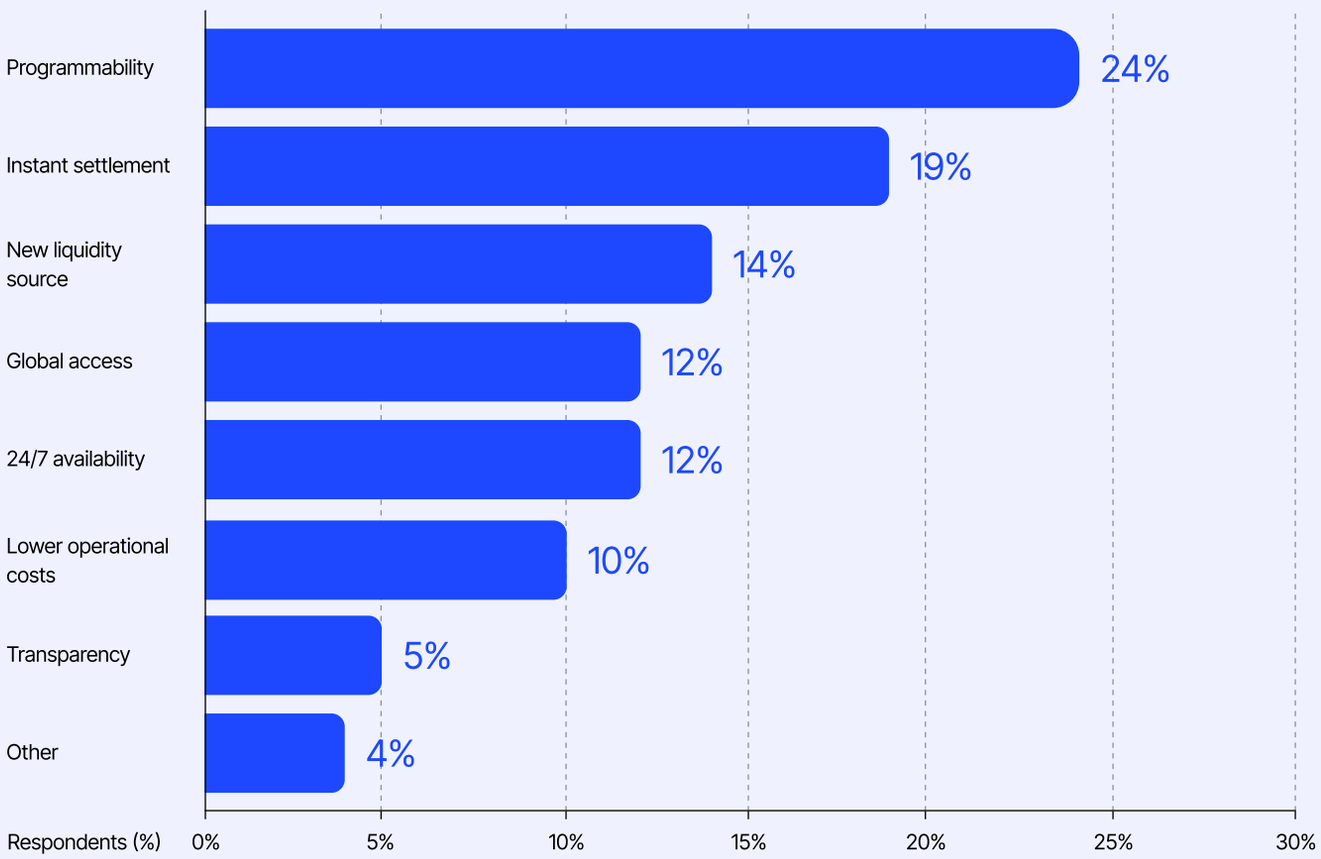
Tokenization isn't the product. Utility is.
After years of experimentation, the market no longer debates whether assets can be tokenized. The real question is what tokenized assets are actually good for, and where they outperform traditional rails in practice.

Onchain wins on utility, not availability. What matters today is what assets can do

When asked to name the single biggest benefit of onchain finance today, respondents rank programmability first at 24%, with instant settlement close behind at 19%.

Features that shaped earlier tokenization narratives, like 24/7 availability and transparency, rank much lower. The advantage operators see today is less about when assets can move, and more about what they can do once onchain.

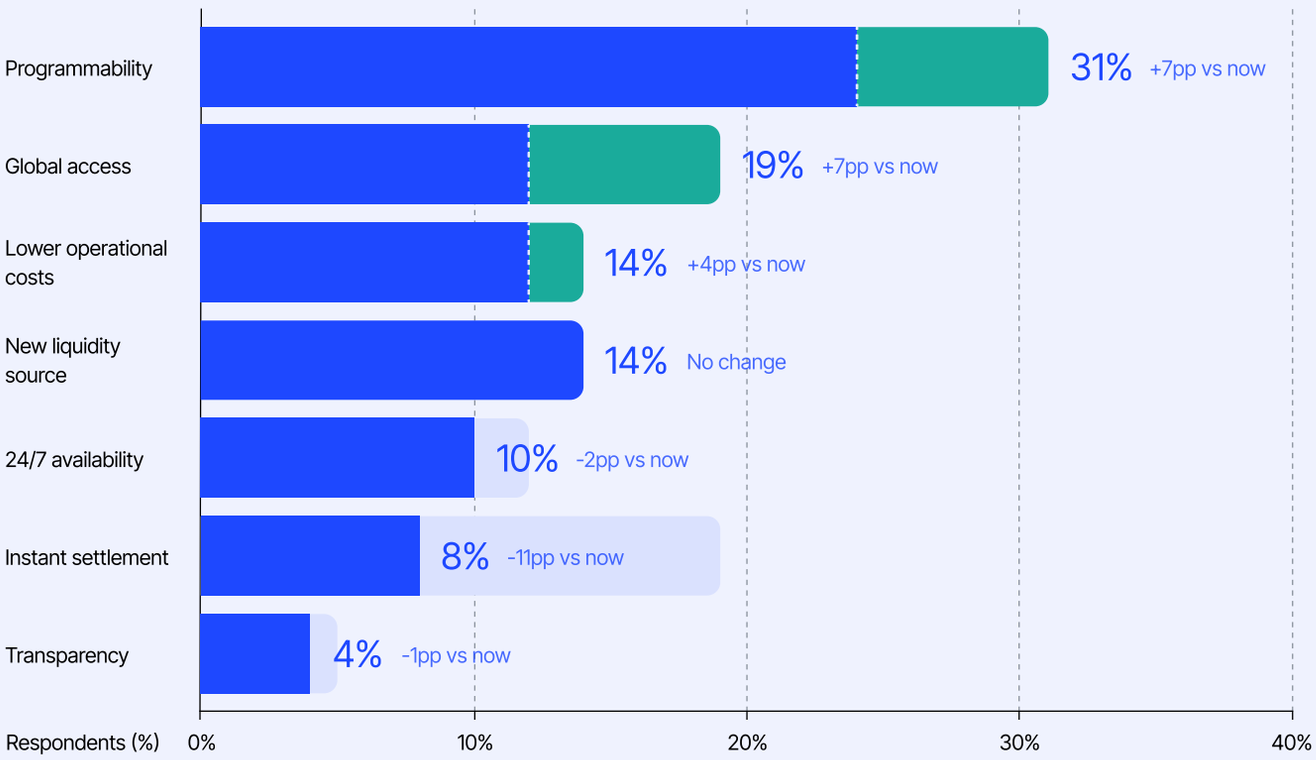
What is the biggest current benefit of onchain finance over traditional rails?



Source: Centrifuge, Tokenization Outlook 2026 Report — centrifuge.io

In 2 years, programmability will matter more. Settlement speed will be expected

Which do you expect will be the biggest benefit of onchain finance in two years?



Source: Centrifuge, Tokenization Outlook 2026 Report — centrifuge.io

Looking two years ahead, respondents increasingly see programmability as the defining structural advantage of onchain finance, rising to 31%.

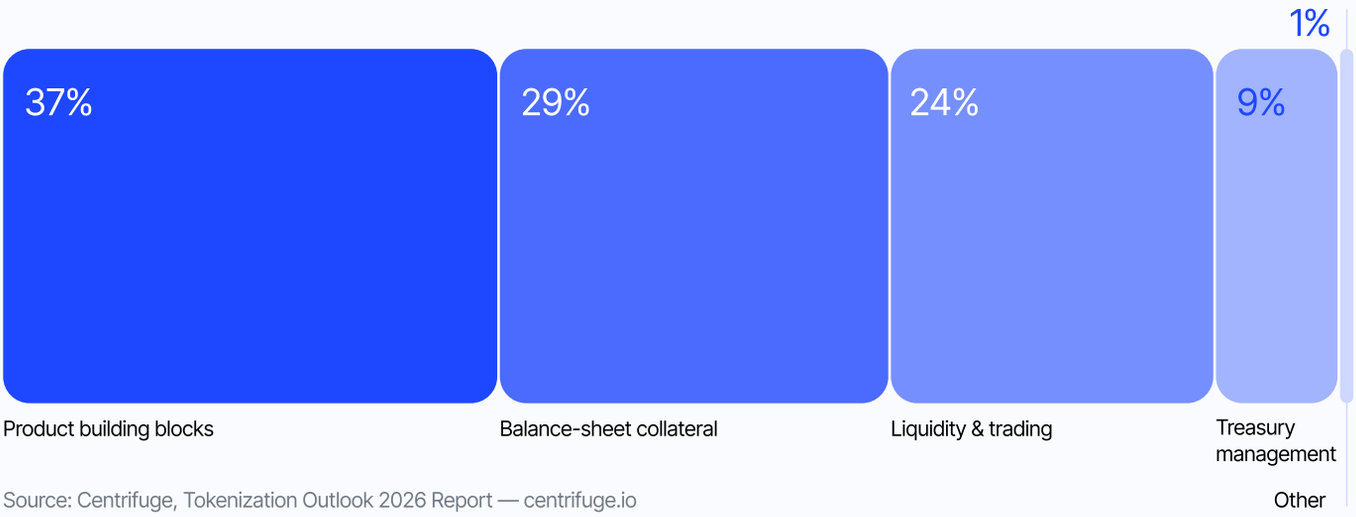
Settlement speed, by contrast, falls from 19% to 8%, the sharpest decline of any benefit, indicating that it is seen as a current operational edge that may become standard over time. Global access rises from 12% to 19%, making it the second-largest projected benefit and reinforcing the long-term value of borderless distribution.

Market makers, exchanges and other liquidity operators are the main exception to the broader two-year view. While most respondents expect programmability to become the leading advantage of onchain finance, this group prioritizes global access instead. That suggests cross-border distribution and market reach matter more to liquidity operators than additional technical functionality.

Long term, collateral and trading emerge as the leading use cases

The shift toward programmability shows up clearly in how respondents think tokenized assets will be used. The long-term view centers on active market functions, not passive treasury allocation.

What will be the primary use case for tokenized assets?



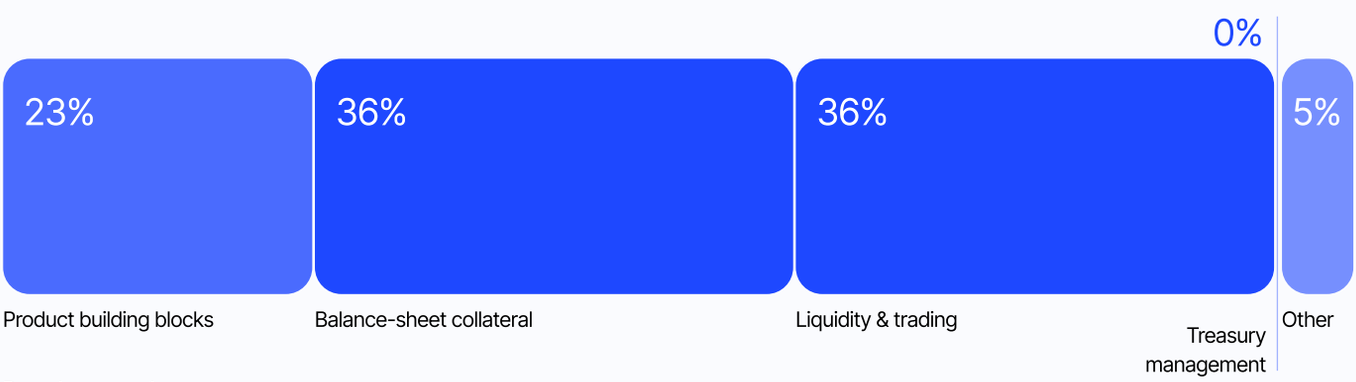
Source: Centrifuge, Tokenization Outlook 2026 Report — centrifuge.io

Product building blocks, balance-sheet collateral, and liquidity & trading account for the clear majority of responses, while treasury management is selected by just 9% as the primary long-term use case.

Active use cases dominate the long-term view. Together, product building blocks and balance-sheet collateral account for 66% of responses, suggesting that tokenized assets are increasingly valued for what they enable inside onchain markets, not simply for passive yield.

Issuers prioritize collateral and trading, not treasury management

Among issuers, balance-sheet collateral and liquidity & trading rank jointly first at 36% each, while none select treasury management. For the teams launching tokenized products, the value lies in utility: borrowing, leverage, and market access, not simply holding yield-bearing assets.



Base: Issuers only

Source: Centrifuge, Tokenization Outlook 2026 Report — centrifuge.io

The value proposition has shifted. Infrastructure needs to shift with it

The conversation has moved beyond “can this be tokenized?” What matters now is what happens after issuance: can an asset be posted as collateral, settle into a lending market, or support reporting without manual reconciliation?

That changes what infrastructure needs to deliver. Settlement speed and 24/7 access helped define the early case for tokenization, and they still matter. But they are becoming expected. The stronger advantage is utility: assets that can be composed into products, reused across venues, and integrated into real market workflows.

It also changes what “utility” means in practice. Tokenized Treasuries helped open the market, but few respondents see them as the end state. Collateral, composability, and trading now point to a broader requirement: infrastructure that supports not just issuance and redemption, but moves up the stack to including onchain structuring and DeFi connectivity.



What this means for infrastructure
Infrastructure can no longer stop at issuance. To support the next phase of tokenized assets, it needs to handle collateral use, market integration, reporting, and asset movement across DeFi and institutional venues.

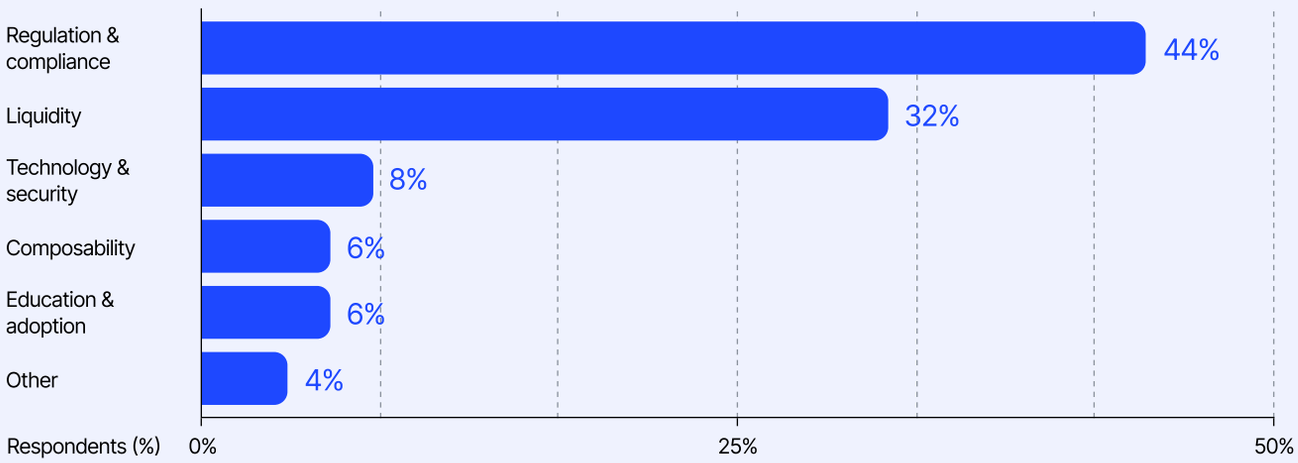
02.

The path to scale

Scaling isn't a technology problem.
Despite technical readiness, tokenized assets struggle to scale because market conditions, not blockchains, haven't caught up. Distribution, liquidity, and regulatory clarity are the real friction points.

Scaling is constrained mostly by regulation. The bottleneck is not technical

What is the biggest bottleneck to scaling tokenized assets today?



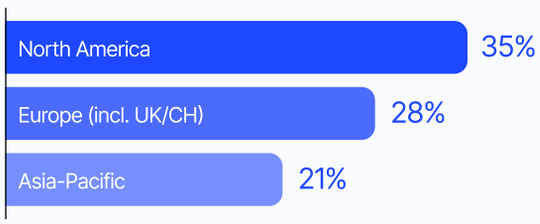
Source: Centrifuge, Tokenization Outlook 2026 Report — centrifuge.io

With 76% of respondents citing regulation and liquidity as the main bottlenecks, the binding constraints are market structure, not technical rails. The question is no longer whether assets can be tokenized, but whether products can reach investors under clear rules and with credible liquidity. Regulatory clarity is widely cited as the big unlock, but it remains the single biggest constraint holding the market back.

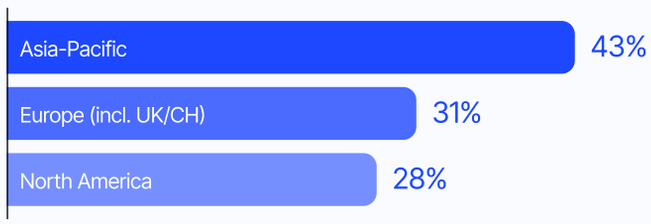
The bottleneck shifts by respondent headquarters: US points to regulation, APAC to liquidity

US-headquartered respondents are the most likely to cite regulation as the primary constraint, while APAC-headquartered respondents point more strongly to liquidity. Europe sits closer to the middle, with liquidity narrowly ahead. The constraint is no longer the rails themselves, but the market conditions around them.

Regulation as the primary bottleneck
by company headquarters



Liquidity as the primary bottleneck
by company headquarters



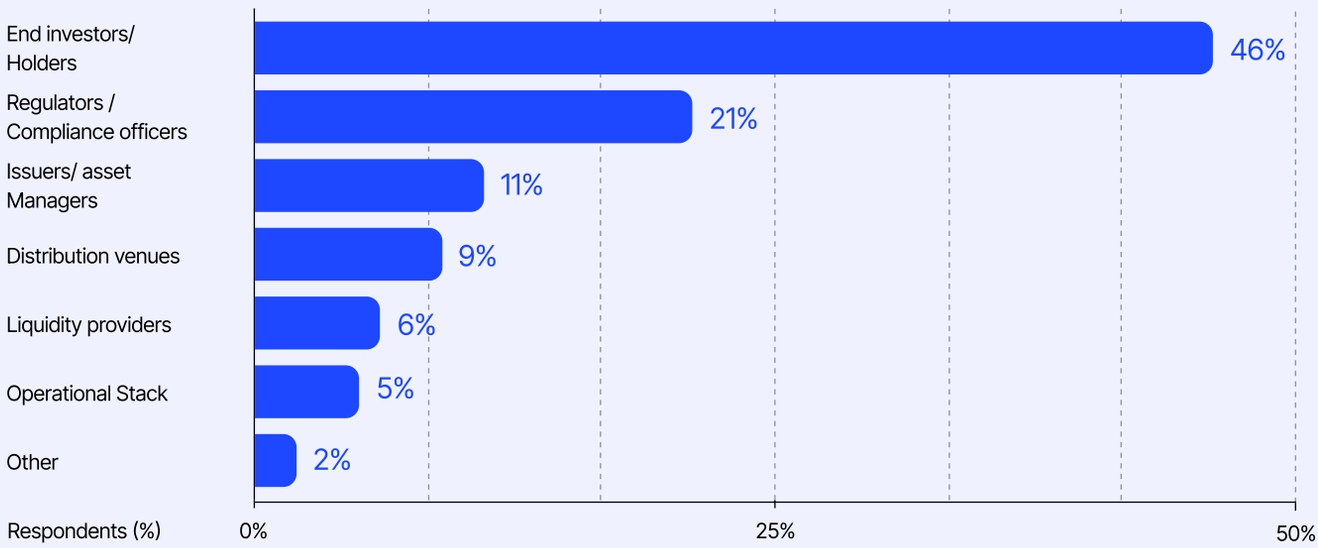
% of operators choosing regulation/liquidity as biggest bottleneck

Source: Centrifuge, Tokenization Outlook 2026 Report — centrifuge.io

Regulatory clarity is a precondition for investor confidence

Operators cite regulation as the biggest bottleneck to scale, but they do not see regulators as the stakeholder whose confidence matters most. They point first to end investors. Regulation matters because it creates the conditions for investor trust, and scale follows trust.

Whose confidence ultimately determines whether tokenized assets reach real scale?



Source: Centrifuge, Tokenization Outlook 2026 Report — centrifuge.io

Liquidity is a symptom, not the root cause

Operators cite liquidity as a bottleneck, but even respondents closest to liquidity, like market makers and exchanges, point first to end investors. That suggests scale depends less on market-making capacity alone and more on investor confidence strong enough to bring demand onchain.

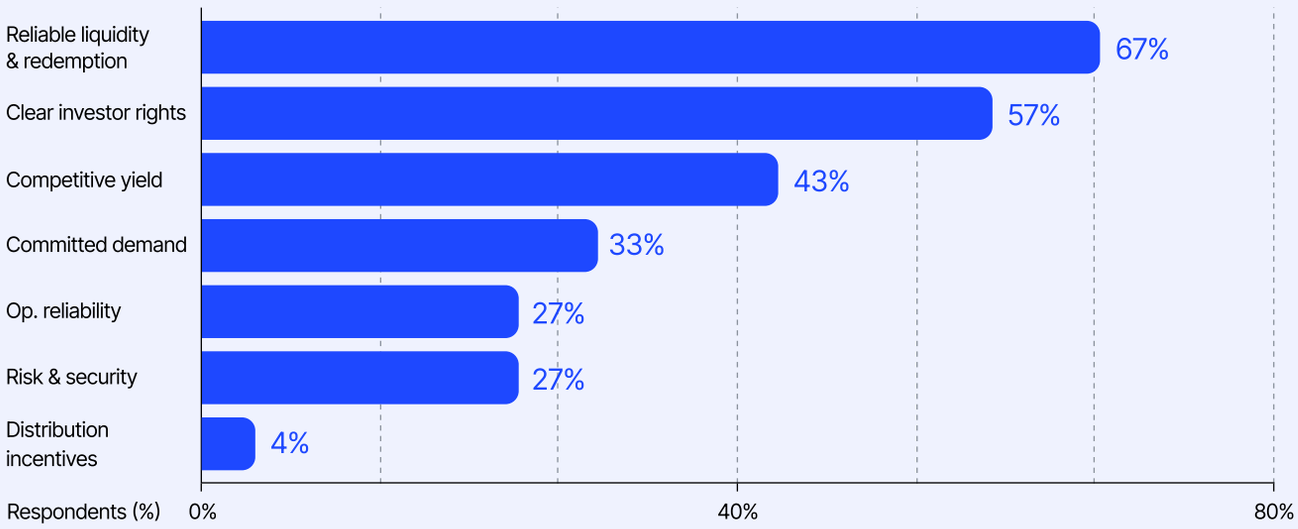
DeFi is more divided on whose confidence unlocks scale

Among all respondents, 46% say end-investor confidence matters most, while 21% point to regulators. Among DeFi venues, that gap narrows to 37% versus 26%. That suggests the crypto-native segment is less convinced that investor demand alone is the decisive constraint, and more likely to see regulatory clarity as a parallel requirement for scale.

Yield may attract interest. Rights and reliability build confidence

If scale depends on attracting new investors, the next question is what operators believe actually gives them confidence. Their answer is not yield alone. Competitive returns may draw attention, but durable confidence depends more on clear investor rights and credible exits.

What do operators believe builds confidence most for end investors?



Source: Centrifuge, Tokenization Outlook 2026 Report — centrifuge.io

When thinking about end investors, respondents place the greatest weight on reliable liquidity and exit, followed by clear investor rights and then competitive yield. That suggests broader adoption depends not just on upside, but on whether tokenized products offer protections and usability that less crypto-native investors can trust. Short-term distribution incentives, by contrast, rank at the bottom.

Where confidence signals diverge

77%

of respondents focused on regulators prioritize clear investor rights, and so do 57% of those focused on end investors. Regardless of which actor they see as decisive, operators converge on the same gap.

58%

of respondents who focused on issuers prioritize competitive yield. Among those focused on end investors, the figure is 43%, suggesting product builders may lean harder on returns than broader investor confidence requires.

60%

of respondents who focused on the operational stack prioritize operational reliability. The figure remains high for regulators at 55%, but falls to 27% for end investors — suggesting process builds institutional trust more than broader investor demand.

Investor confidence: the missing layer between tokenization and scale

With 76% of operators pointing to regulation and liquidity as the binding constraints and only 8% citing technology, the message is clear: the challenge is no longer issuance alone. What has not yet scaled is investor trust, the layer between a tokenized product and the capital willing to allocate to it.

The survey points to a specific pattern. End-investor confidence is seen as the most important condition for real scale, by a 2:1 margin over the next closest factor. But respondents do not associate that confidence with yield alone. They tie it to reliable liquidity and exit, clear investor rights, and competitive returns within products that feel operationally credible.

That distinction matters. Yield may attract attention, but the market is increasingly asking what kind of yield a tokenized asset delivers and what makes it durable. Is it simply wrapped exposure, or does it come with utility: collateral use, secondary liquidity, integration into lending and trading venues, and clearer pathways to exit?

The implication is practical. The next phase of adoption will favor products that shorten an allocator's diligence process, where investor protections are embedded, exits are credible, and the value of the asset extends beyond passive holding into actual market use.

What this means for builders

The next phase of adoption will not be won by bringing more assets onchain alone. It will be won by products that give investors clear rights, credible exit paths, and reasons to hold the asset beyond passive exposure. In practice, that means reducing the diligence burden: making protections visible, liquidity believable, and utility clear enough for capital to move.

03.

The next phase of adoption

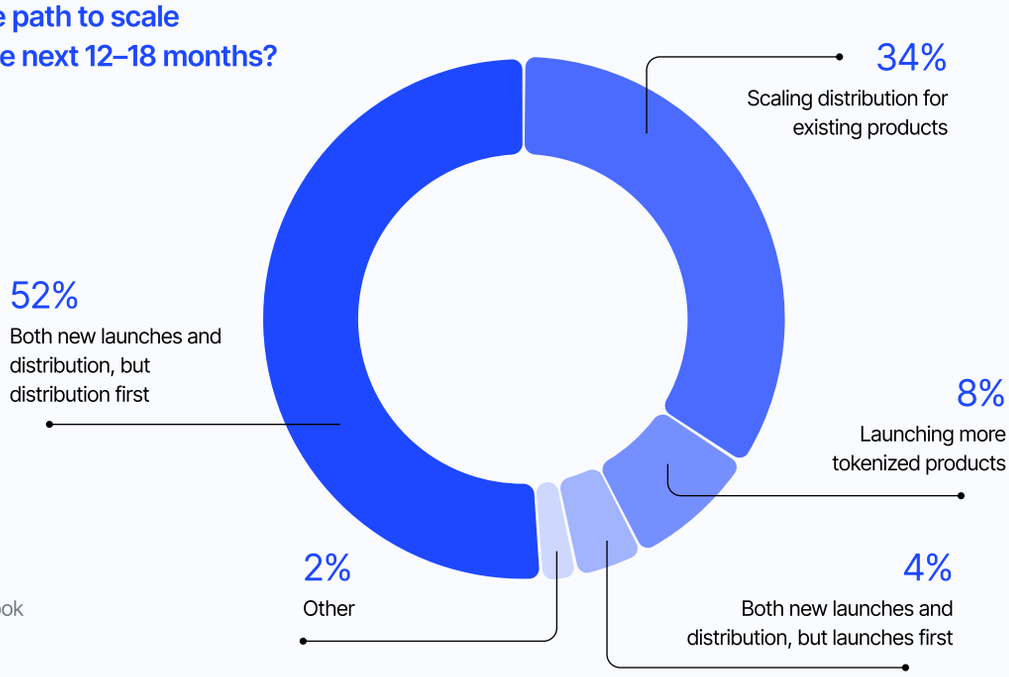
The next phase of tokenization is taking shape.
What changes next is not just what comes onchain, but where adoption takes hold first, through which channels, and with whom.

Distribution now matters more than launching more products

Nearly 9 in 10 operators, across every category, company size, and geography, say the priority has shifted from product supply to distribution. That is the broadest point of consensus in the survey, wider than any single view on regulation, liquidity, or technology. The question is less whether tokenized products can be launched, and more how they reach hands, wallets, and venues.

Only 8% say launching more tokenized products should be the priority. Even among that group, liquidity is still the main concern, suggesting respondents see new issuance as a way to improve market depth and product fit, not as an end in itself. What remains open is which channels will actually carry adoption first.

Which is the more effective path to scale tokenized products over the next 12–18 months?



Source: Centrifuge, Tokenization Outlook 2026 Report — centrifuge.io

Why new issuance still matters, but less than distribution

Distribution drives adoption
"Distribution and integration drive liquidity and real usage. Without secondary venues, collateral use cases, and institutional access, new issuance alone will not scale adoption."

Financial Analyst I Investment Banking

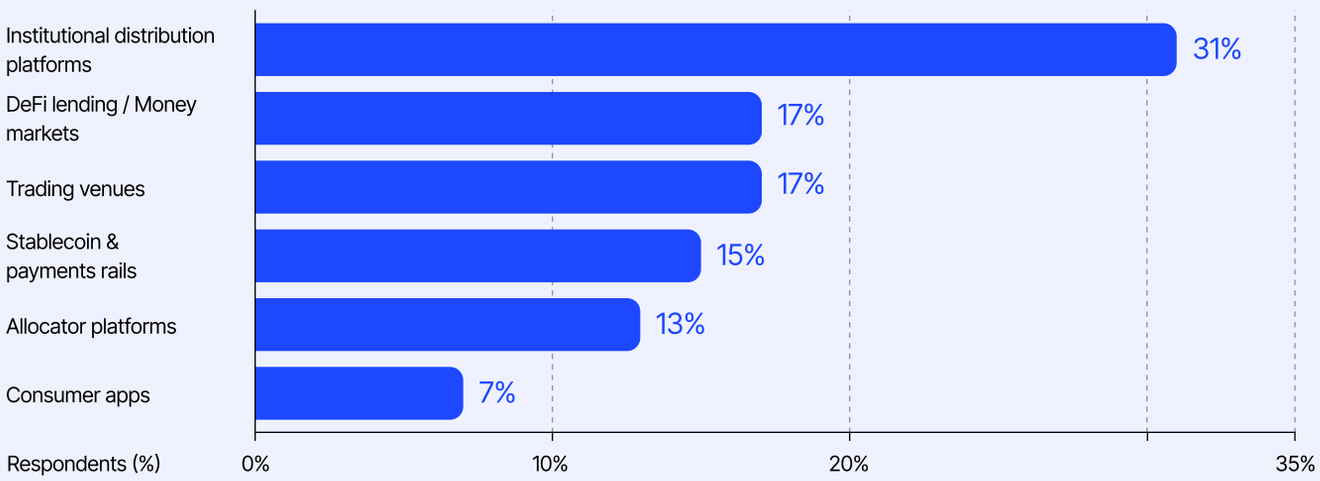
Broader product choice still matters
"The current choice of assets is still limited. Issuing more will help bring different risk profiles which can be distributed more effectively."

Head of Growth | DeFi protocol

Distribution will be multi-channel. There's no breakaway winner

Institutional platforms lead as the integration operators expect to drive the most adoption over the next 12–18 months, but only at 31%. The top three channels capture 65% of responses, pointing to a multi-channel future rather than a single distribution winner.

Over the next 12–18 months, which integration will drive the most adoption (demand/volume) for tokenized assets?

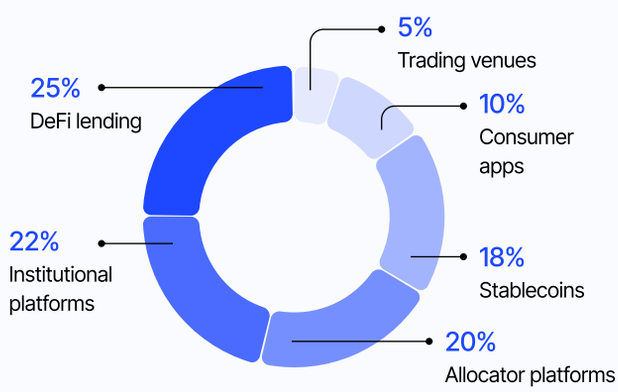


Source: Centrifuge, Tokenization Outlook 2026 Report — centrifuge.io

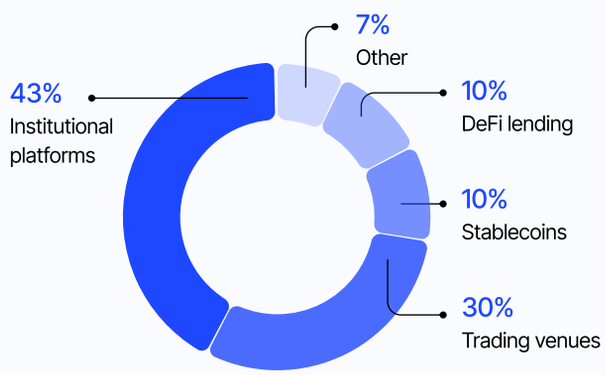
Why no single channel captures more than a third: channel preference follows use case

Channel preference depends on the kind of adoption respondents expect. When they picture connected financial products, preferences spread across several channels. When they picture collateral use, they concentrate much more heavily in institutional platforms and trading venues.

When respondents expect adoption through connected financial products



When respondents expect adoption through collateral use

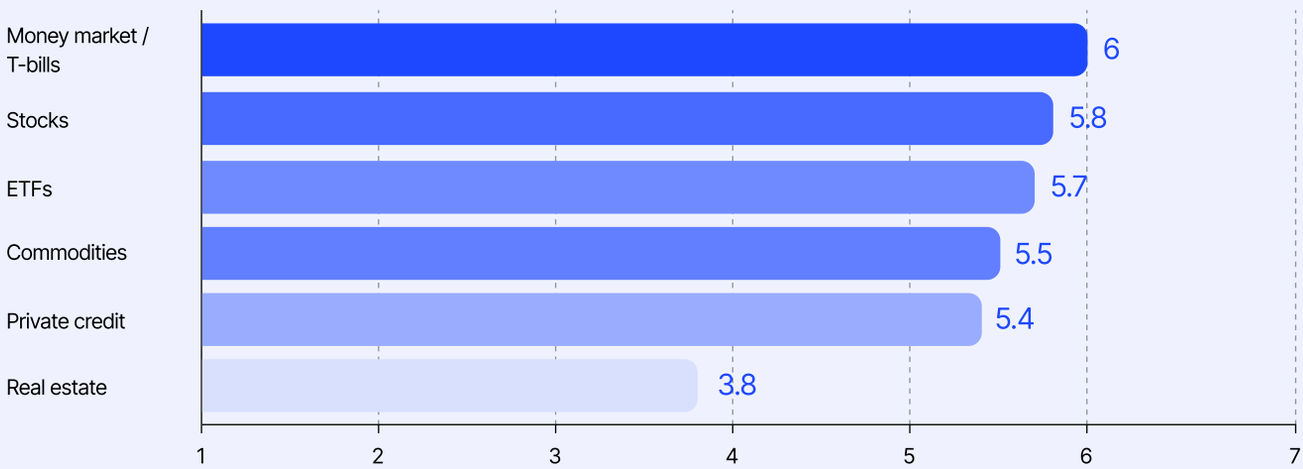


Source: Centrifuge, Tokenization Outlook 2026 Report — centrifuge.io

Money markets and stocks lead expectations for onchain purchase by 2030

Crossing a majority-onchain threshold remains a high bar, but money markets and stocks come closest. Five of six asset classes score above the midpoint, suggesting operators see broad potential, but uneven readiness across categories.

How likely is it that over half of this asset class will be purchased onchain by 2030?



Average score on a scale from 1 to 10.

Source: Centrifuge, Tokenization Outlook 2026 Report — centrifuge.io

Real estate is the clearest outlier, reflecting its physical, illiquid, and jurisdiction-bound structure. Private credit sits just above the midpoint, but with the tightest clustering in the mid-range, suggesting cautious but relatively aligned expectations. Money markets show the strongest high-conviction profile, while stocks and ETFs score positively without yet reflecting breakout certainty.

How conviction differs by asset class

	Low (1-3)	Mid (4-6)	High (7-8)	Very high (9-10)
Money market / T-bills	23%	27%	33%	17%
Stocks	25%	32%	27%	16%
ETFs	25%	31%	27%	17%
Commodities	28%	36%	22%	14%
Private credit	23%	42%	30%	6%
Real estate	52%	36%	8%	4%

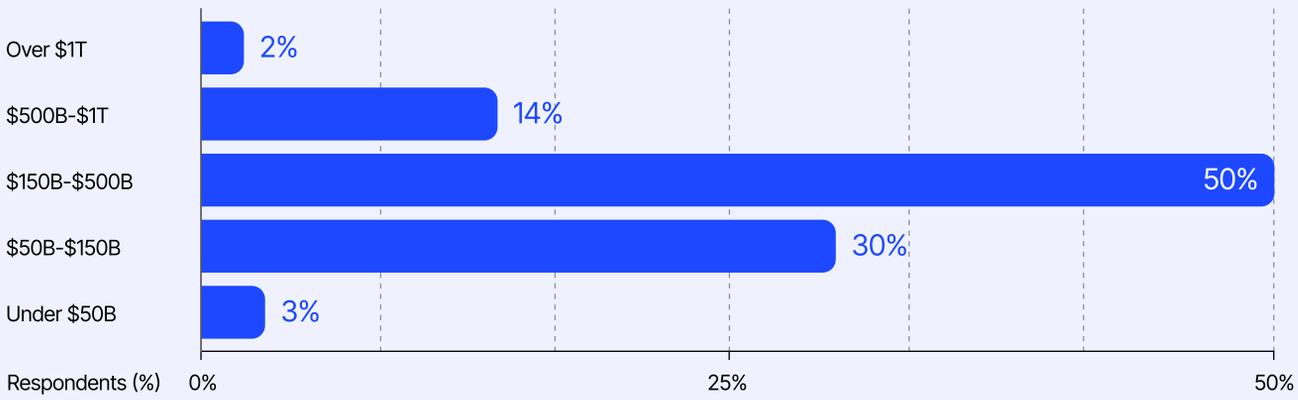
Share of respondents by score bucket

Source: Centrifuge, Tokenization Outlook 2026 Report — centrifuge.io

By 2027, operators expect meaningful growth in onchain AUM, but not a breakout

Half of respondents place tokenized asset AUM in the $150B–$500B range by end-2027, while 80% cluster between $50B and $500B. The outlook points to significant growth in institutional adoption, but expectations diverge meaningfully by company headquarters and size.

By end of 2027, tokenized asset AUM onchain will be:



Source: Centrifuge, Tokenization Outlook 2026 Report — centrifuge.io

How expectations diverge:

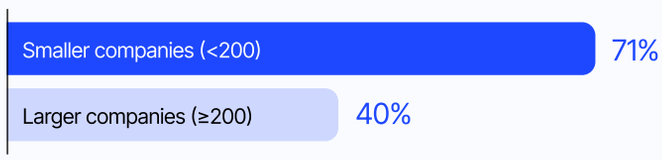
US more confident than Europe for near-term RWA AUM growth.
While North America-based respondents project higher near-term AUM ranges, Europeans skew more conservative: nearly half place 2027 onchain AUM at $150B or below.

Larger companies hold a more conservative outlook.
Companies with 200+ employees are less likely than smaller operators to project onchain AUM above $150B by 2027, suggesting greater caution on near-term market growth.

AUM outlook by company headquarters
Share expecting more than $150B AUM by 2027



AUM outlook by company size
Share expecting more than $150B AUM by 2027



Source: Centrifuge, Tokenization Outlook 2026 Report — centrifuge.io

The product exists. Now it needs to work everywhere

The question facing tokenized assets is no longer whether supply will materialize. It has. What the industry now has to solve is distribution across channels: how a single product reaches a DeFi lending market, a wealth platform, and a brokerage account without rebuilding the integration each time.

That challenge is operational, not theoretical. A tokenized fund that works on one venue but needs significant manual adaptation for the next is not scalable distribution. The more integration work each new channel requires, the slower adoption compounds.

That is why the survey points to progress without breakout. Operators are not waiting for more products. They are describing the infrastructure conditions required for adoption to compound: portability across venues, embedded trust, and operational consistency. The gap between where tokenized assets are today and where this market expects them to go is not a product gap. It is an infrastructure gap.

What this means next

The next phase will depend less on creating more supply, and more on infrastructure that makes existing products usable across markets. But utility alone is not enough: scale also requires the regulatory clarity and investor protections that give allocators confidence to move capital onchain. The operators best positioned are those solving for both.

Centrifuge

Tokenization is the foundation. What gets built on top of it is what matters

The market is moving beyond issuance alone. Distribution is the binding constraint, and the value of onchain finance lies in making assets functional: usable as collateral, integrated across venues, and accessible through the channels where capital already moves.

That is the phase Centrifuge is built for. Not just bringing assets onchain, but making them work there: through distribution infrastructure, onchain asset management, and integration into the markets where adoption compounds.

Made exclusively for

Real-World Asset Summit

For partnerships:



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